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1929, Jinnah and Bhagat Singh

As Bhagat Singh spent his formative years in Lahore, one would think that he would not be forgotten there. And so it has proved to be the case. This is despite his family having moved back to the Jalandhar district in India after the Partition of 1947 and despite Bhagat Singh's exclusion from official Pakistan narratives as a national icon, given the country's adopted policy of Islamicization in the 1970s. In fact, there is a forgotten link between the nation's founding father and Bhagat Singh which has still to be fully acknowledged by Pakistan's intellectuals. In the words of Shoaib Daniyal, although '[m]uch has been written about the Mohandas Gandhi-Bhagat Singh dynamic', the irony is that far '[l]ess is known, though, of the dynamic between Mahomed Ali Jinnah (as he spelt the name) and Bhagat Singh'. Of course, the two men, in terms of background and upbringing, were poles apart. Yet, they were united in one distinctive respect. Both recognized they were fighting the British for the Independence of their people. As such, neither flinched at standing up for fairness and justice. Daniyal [1] writes that although 'Jinnah in 1931 was a politician who had missed the bus as far as Congress-style mass politics would be concerned', nevertheless, '[h]e was still at the high table of Indian politics . . .' However, the difference between the two men could not have been more stark in that 'Jinnah strongly believed in constitutionalism, reposing faith in the institutions of Empire such as legislatures, courts and even the British Parliament to deliver progress to India', while 'Marxist-Leninist Bhagat Singh was, of course, the polar opposite, believing that violent armed struggle was a legitimate way to overthrow the Raj'.